SKIN MOMENT

how to support your skin during pregnancy

THE FOUNDATION OF TRUE CARE

Build your routine

Your body is about to change faster than it ever has, and your skin has to keep up. The good news is that helping it is simple: what you eat, what you drink, how active you are and what you put on before bed all affect how your skin reacts, and if you are smart about them, they work in your favor. Those steps are easy. The only hard part is doing them and staying consistent.

Here is what is recommended, and what each one actually does.

What is recommended, and why

What is recommended	The explanation
Eat more protein or drink a protein shake	Your skin is held together by fibers, and those fibers are made of protein. As your belly grows, your skin has to keep making new ones, and it can only make them out of what you eat. Your baby gets first pick of everything, so when protein is short, your skin is the one that goes without. Have some at every meal. When nausea takes over, or there is simply no time to cook, a shake is the easiest way to get protein in.
Eat more healthy fats	Fat is what keeps water inside your skin. Soft skin stretches as your belly grows, dry skin resists and tears. Olive oil, avocado, nuts, seeds and oily fish will do it, and you do not need large amounts of them.
Take omega-3	Omega-3 is a fat your body cannot make on its own, so it has to come from food. What it does is bring inflammation down. That matters here, because a stretching belly often leaves skin irritated and itchy, and irritated skin rebuilds more slowly. Salmon, sardines or trout a couple of times a week, and most prenatals include it as DHA.
Drink more water	Your skin is mostly water. When you are drinking enough, it stays soft and stretches with your belly. When there is not enough, it tears more easily. Your blood and the fluid around your baby take water first, so your skin gets what is left. Keep a bottle nearby and drink through the day.
Take vitamins C, D, E and zinc	Eating protein is not enough on its own. Your body needs vitamin C to turn it into collagen, so if you are low on vitamin C, the fibers it builds come out weaker. Zinc is what your skin uses to make new cells, vitamin E protects them while they are forming, and vitamin D keeps the skin renewing at a steady pace. All four are in your prenatal. Ask for blood work and add extra only if something is actually low.
Take your prenatal	Stretch marks happen when skin is pulled faster than it can rebuild itself, and rebuilding takes supplies. Iron, folic acid, and more. Your body hands everything to the baby first, which is why you are the one who ends up short. A prenatal covers what your food misses. Take the one your doctor recommends.
Drink collagen	Collagen is the fiber that tears when a mark appears, so it makes sense to give your body more of what it builds that fiber from. A plain collagen powder does exactly that, and it counts towards your protein for the day.
Use a moisturizer every day	Your skin dries out through the day, and dry skin is more likely to tear. Your belly should look like a glazed donut at all times. Keep it simple and fragrance-free, and smooth it on morning and evening, while your skin is still damp from the shower, on the belly, hips, breasts and thighs.
Use Centella asiatica and hyaluronic acid	Hyaluronic acid draws water into the skin and holds it there. It works best as a serum, on damp skin, before your moisturizer goes on top to seal it in. A moisturizer with Centella calms irritation, which stretching skin has plenty of, and is easy to find. Short ingredient list, no retinol, nothing heavily perfumed.

What is recommended	The explanation
Massage the belly	Everything your skin builds with arrives in your blood, and massage brings that blood up to where the work is happening. It takes the tight feeling away too, and it turns the cream from a chore into a few minutes you look forward to. Slow circles, light pressure.
Dry brush before the shower	Dry brushing is another way to get the blood moving, and it clears the dead skin off the surface so your cream sits better. Light strokes with a soft brush before you shower. Keep it gentle, and leave it if your skin is sore or irritated.
Stay physically active	Movement is on this list for the same reason as massage. Your blood circulates better, and blood is what carries everything your skin needs to keep rebuilding while it stretches. Walking, swimming, prenatal yoga, light weights. Confirm with your doctor when you can start and how intense it should be.
Control weight gain	Gaining weight is part of a healthy pregnancy, not something to fight. Your doctor can help you understand the right range and pace for you. Gaining slowly gives your skin time to build as it goes, while a sudden jump pulls it faster than it can keep up with, and that is when marks show. Trying to avoid stretch marks is never a reason to eat less than you need.
Read the full ingredient list	A few things work against the skin you are looking after. Retinol and tretinoin are out completely while you are pregnant. Essential oils and creams with a long list of actives irritate easily, and irritated skin handles the stretch worse. Turn the box over and read the back. If you are not sure about something, take it to your doctor.

One thing to remember

Stretch marks are not a reflection of how well you cared for yourself. Family history and the skin you were born with carry more weight than anything you apply, and none of it was your choice. Good nutrition and consistent care give your skin its best chance, but they cannot promise you nine months without stretch marks.

About the evidence

For understandable reasons, clinical studies are rarely conducted during pregnancy, so the evidence in this area is limited. Please confirm with your physician what is right for you.

Natalia Boleyn is a skin practitioner, not a physician. This guide is educational and does not replace medical advice. Please speak with your doctor before making any changes.